Politics on the Menu:

Political Identity, Consumer Sorting, and Restaurant Engagement

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Economics Research Seminar
April 12, 2024

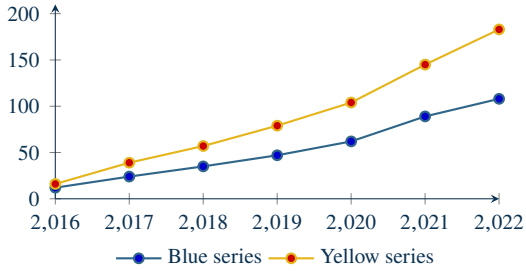
1. Motivation

POLITICAL IDENTITY MEETS EVERYDAY CONSUMPTION

Why Do Political Identities Matter in Everyday Choices?

- Political identity may influence not only what people think, but also where they choose to spend time and money.
- Restaurants are a salient social space where political identity can shape consumer behavior beyond explicit politics.
- We study restaurant choice, engagement, and consumer sorting across politically identified establishments.

Growth in Politically Identified Restaurant Reviews



2. Data

POLITICAL IDENTITY MEETS EVERYDAY CONSUMPTION

Data and Measurement

OpenRice review archive

- 2,269,004 district-resolved eligible reviews.
- 260,911 reviewers and 39,199 establishments.
- Research window: 2016–2025.

Takeaway. The color labels are measurement devices. White does not mean politically neutral.

Three-color classification

Group	Restaurants
Yellow	3,837
Blue	2,469
White	32,893

3. Empirical Strategy

POLITICAL IDENTITY MEETS EVERYDAY CONSUMPTION

Empirical Strategy and Main Results

Empirical Strategy

1. Compare allocation across fixed restaurant color groups.
2. Match restaurants around first qualifying Yellow reviews.
3. Estimate conditional review choice across Yellow, Blue, and White restaurants.

Main Results

	Count	Rating
Months +1 to +3	0.233***	0.983***
	(0.031)	(0.242)
Months +4 to +6	0.251***	1.289***
	(0.036)	(0.258)
Months +7 to +12	0.192***	1.031***
	(0.042)	(0.243)

Notes: illustrative layout using manuscript estimates.

4. Results

POLITICAL IDENTITY MEETS EVERYDAY CONSUMPTION

Conditional Review Choice

Main message

Estimated availability makes early residual Yellow attraction model-sensitive; the reopening-period decline persists.

- Availability differs from proportional adjustment.
- Early attraction depends on supply normalization.
- The late negative Yellow index remains across specifications.

Model object

Conditional allocation across colors, holding district-quarter activity and recorded restaurant stock fixed.

5. Conclusion

POLITICAL IDENTITY MEETS EVERYDAY CONSUMPTION

Conclusion

- Market sorting, public identity expression, and business evaluation are related but not interchangeable.
- Local attention-associated gains can coexist with weaker later aggregate attraction.
- The evidence concerns recorded reviews and ratings, not political tastes, transactions, or welfare.

Takeaway. Use navy for structure, yellow for emphasis, and white space for the identification story.